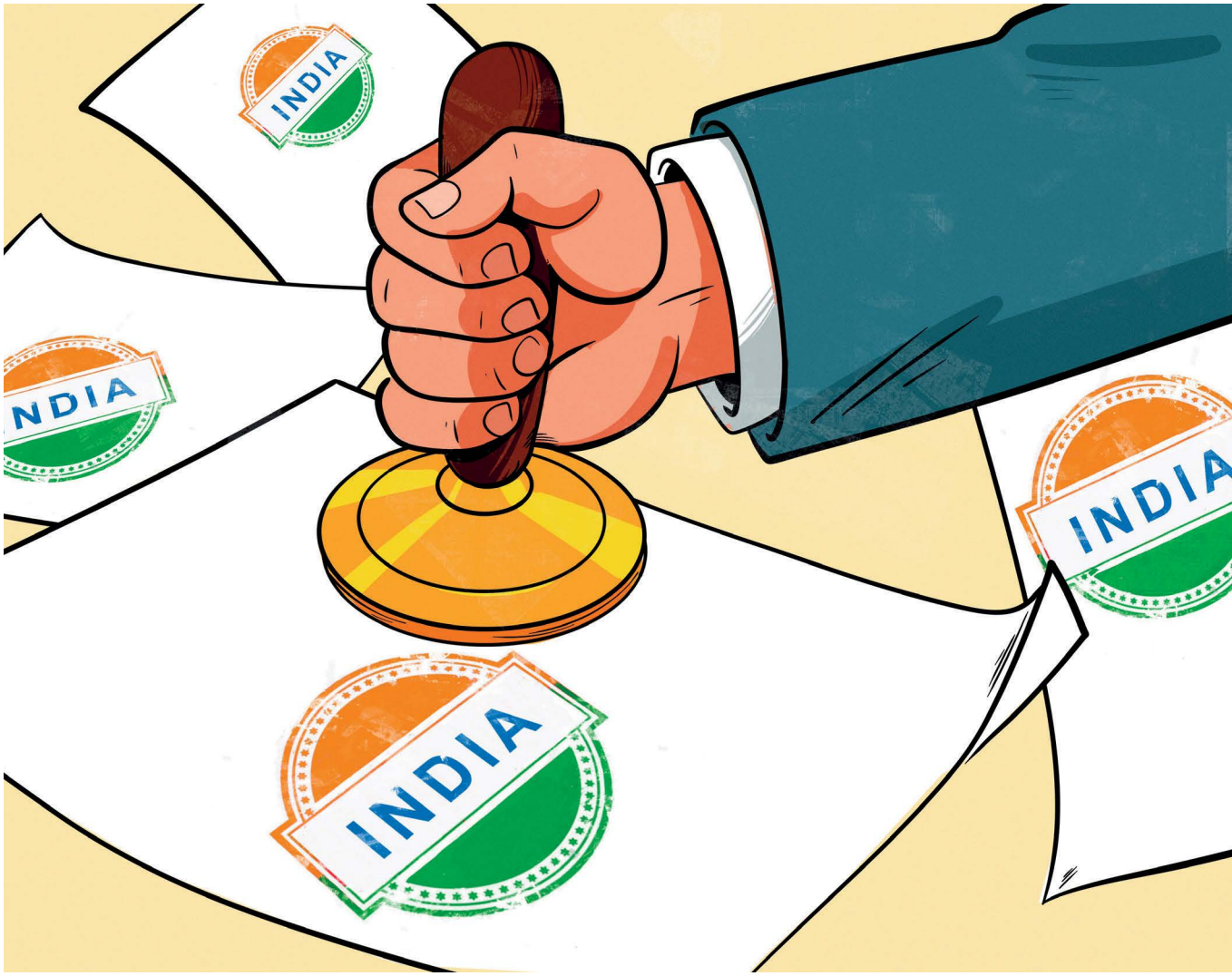


Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

rejected? It was indeed an improbable scenario, a satirical conjecture of what would be one of the greatest turnabouts of history. But this ironic twist in the tale also revealed something else: the enduring allure of the name India, a coveted geographical marker in antiquity—Indica, Indies, Hind, Hindustan, and India, cognates of the Sanskrit Sindhu river—repackaged into Brand India in the 21st-century world economy.

Brand India came into its own at the turn of the millennium, its global Indian identity reified as a precious resource that could be refashioned into a desirable commodity brand in the world economy. What had begun in the mid-'90s as a bid to promote 'Made in India' products would eventually become 'Make in India', the nation as a manufacturing hub, about three decades later. Yet, unlike China, India had not only opened up its economy to the world, it could also boast of being the "world's largest free-market democracy". Thus, Brand India came to cohere both liberal politics and a liberal economy, an entity whose emergence was celebrated and consecrated through mass publicity campaigns. From the iconic Incredible India campaign launched in 2002, India Shining 2003-4, India Everywhere 2006, Davos, to Lead India 2007, and from Skill India, Clean India to Digital India, Brand India emerged as an influential locus of interaction with the world and the nation. It projected a liberal personality of the nation even as it mediated the nation's resources: natural landscapes, people, and cultures. The Incredible India images are especially noteworthy in how natural—the mountains, deserts, forests, rivers and oceans—and cultural elements are re-inscribed through the brand, to become inseparable from its commodity form.

A telling example of how Brand India joined the past and the future is an India Shining global campaign advertisement. It nudged global visitors to set "sail for our beautiful shores". The image featured an artistic depiction of Columbus's arrival on the American continent and bold text that read "The last time we held so much promise, Columbus discovered America". The smaller text beneath explains that "when Columbus set sail to find the rich spices of our land, destiny had other plans. Instead of finding us, he discovered America. Years later, modern-day explorers have got our Incredible land back on their maps". The allusion was to the story of Christopher Columbus's search for the legendary India that had long existed in European imagination